

of ‘skills’ they all need to have because they will be essentially doing the same or similar kind of routine work in a large team such as, by and large, fixing bugs, releasing patches, making enhancements, etc. I could subject them to a standardised test and if they score, say, 80% or more, then they are in. My average team size, for all I know, might be ~200 or ~300 engineers in some lights-on work where, by nature, the work requires following a standardized process to work on the ‘ticket’ and check-in the code. This is not a ‘version 1.0’ (is perhaps more like a version 4.7.2), nor does it possess the inherent risk of creating NTTW (New To The World) product or service. At most, we are talking of a derivative, by and large, of course exceptions notwithstanding. Yes, there might be a what I call ‘volume complexity,’ but surely not ‘value complexity.’ I call this class of workers as ‘labour,’ and they are literally available a dime a dozen!

#### ***Tathagat’s Corollary of Labour***

**Hiring:** Hiring 300 engineers is far easier than hiring 3!

On the other hand, when you are highly selective and extremely choosy in hiring just three engineers, you are, by definition, almost looking for rocket scientists and neurosurgeons. Contextually, it is extremely likely that you are hiring for a small elite team of just five to seven engineers and hence you need rock-solid engineers. Perhaps you are building the next Twitter, or the next Uber, or the next Cisco, or even better...the ‘first something!’ And you need the talent that has the gumption to walk on burning coals and come out smiling. You need them to be a self-starter and someone who is not shy of sticking their neck out.

For all you know, they might not always have all the required tech skills, but does that really matter? To overcompensate for lack of what is ‘unknown unknown,’ they have a highly evolved critical thinking mindset and a problem solving system that gives them



the courage to walk into the toughest situation and come out shining (along with the scars to show for it)! No, those folks do not grow on trees. They are not your average mass-scale labour. They are your talent, and they are rare.

First of all, that is ‘1% market.’

They are not excited by the boring routine problems. They want to solve 1% tough problems. They are good, and they know it, and they have stuff to show that they are good. Some of them might well be on the paths to become legends in future.

Second, chances are very high that another half-a-dozen companies (read ‘well-funded’) are also chasing that 1% talent. If you are slow, you will be left behind.

Third, as much as you are hiring them, they are also hiring you! Do not expect them to passively accept whatever you tell them. In fact, if they think your hiring process was meh (uninspiring), they might lose interest—they want to win a hard fight, not a walkover. If your story is not tight, they just won’t look at you.

Fourth, the 1% talent marketplace is a high-stakes table. Since there are not too many players here, the stakes

simply go higher. So, if you want a 1% talent but only willing to pay for a 20% market, then you should count yourself out.

#### ***Tathagat’s Corollary of Talent***

**Hiring:** Hiring 3 engineers is a lot harder than hiring 300!

So, what does it really mean?

For one, hiring is not a scale-free competency. Simply because someone has hired hundreds of engineers in the last job means nothing if you need to hire just a handful of them. On the contrary, it might be a disqualification. Apart from the capability, it simply needs a different mindset to operate in the ‘vital few’ talent market vs the ‘trivial many’ labour market. And, finally, if the company’s leadership is not quite bought into the diseconomics of talent hiring, they might be in it for a long time to come!

And hopefully you also finally understand why you are not able to hire just those three engineers while your neighbour LargeCo is able to hire 300 without a sweat! **END** 🐧

**By: Tathagat Varma**

The author is a strategy leader and AI researcher.

*The article was originally published in the July 2021 issue of Electronics For You.*